

Netherlands



A low-lying country that once controlled a wealthy international trading empire.

400s CE After the departure of the Romans, three Germanic tribes (Franks in the south, Frisians in the north, Saxons in the east) assert control.

768–814 During the reign of Charlemagne, the Franks conquer the whole of the Netherlands; after his death the region becomes part of the Middle Frankish kingdom and then of the East Frankish kingdom, later the Holy Roman Empire.

1000s Decline of central authority leads to a feudal fragmentation and the formation of autonomous states; the county of Holland, in the west, becomes the dominant power in the region.

1433 Holland becomes a Burgundian possession by inheritance, and part of the Habsburg Empire in 1482.

1515–55 During the reign of Charles V, all the remaining autonomous territories become Habsburg possessions; the Netherlands is thus united for the first time; on Charles's abdication they come under Spanish Habsburg rule.

1567 Resistance to Philip II of Spain, fueled in part by the rise of Protestantism, leads to a popular revolt led by William (the Silent) of Orange, sections of the nobility, and the powerful merchant class.

1581 The seven northern provinces formally declare their independence from Spain and form the Republic of the United Provinces of the Netherlands.

1602 Dutch East India Company is founded, locating its headquarters at Batavia, now Jakarta, in 1619. The company develops a major maritime trading empire in the East Indies.

1609 Twelve-year truce with Spain begins, but founders over demand for recognition of religious freedoms.

Golden Age

These elegant merchants' houses date from Amsterdam's 17th-century "Golden Age," when the city was the wealthiest in the world and at the hub of international trade.



1614 Dutch traders begin to trade and form colonies on the Hudson River in North America; the colonies are seized by Britain in 1664.

1648 The Peace of Munster confirms Dutch independence, ending the so-called 80 Years War of independence.

1652–74 The Dutch fight three wars with Britain over control of maritime trade.

1689–1702 William of Orange, the hereditary stadtholder, or provincial leader, becomes king of England and campaigns against Louis XIV of France.

1713 The Treaty of Utrecht, ends both the War of the Spanish Succession and Dutch involvement in European power struggles.

1795 French forces invade; local groups proclaim the Batavian Republic, modeled on revolutionary France.

1806 Holland again becomes a kingdom under Louis Bonaparte, but is annexed by France four years later.

1813 Dutch oust French and choose to become a constitutional monarchy.

1815 Congress of Vienna: United Kingdom of Netherlands formed that includes Belgium and Luxembourg.

1830 Belgium revolts and secedes; its independence is recognized by the Netherlands in 1839.

1848 New constitution: ministers to be accountable to parliament.

1897–1901 Wide-ranging social legislation enacted.

1898 Wilhelmina succeeds to throne, ending Luxembourg union where male hereditary Salic Law is in force.

1914–18 Dutch neutrality respected in World War I.

1919 Women fully enfranchised.

1940 Dutch assert neutrality in World War II, but Nazi Germany invades and meets fierce resistance to the occupation.

1942 Japan invades Dutch East Indies.

1944–45 "Winter of starvation" in German-occupied western provinces.

1945 Liberation. International Court of Justice set up in the Hague in 1946.

1946–58 Labor Party (PvdA) under Willem Drees leads center-left coalitions as the country rebuilds after the war.

1948 Juliana becomes queen.

1948 Customs union with Belgium and Luxembourg (Benelux) comes into operation.

1949 Most of the East Indies colonies gain independence as Indonesia after a four-year guerrilla war.

1957 Founder member of the EEC.

1960 Economic union with Belgium and Luxembourg comes into effect.

1963 The final Dutch colony in the East Indies—Western New Guinea—is relinquished to Indonesia.

1973 PvdA wins power after 15 years in opposition and leads a center-left coalition.

1977–81 Coalition formed by the Christian Democrats (CDA) and the People's Party (VVD).

1980 CDA alliance of the "confessional" parties forms a single party.

1980 Beatrix becomes queen.

2000 Licensed brothels legalized.

2002 Adopts the euro.

2002 Government resigns after the Dutch army is blamed for not preventing the Srebrenica massacre in Bosnia.

2002 Right-wing populist Pim Fortuyn

is assassinated; his party becomes second largest in parliament and joins the government. The coalition collapses in 2003.

2005 Dutch voters reject a proposed EU constitution.

NETHERLANDS

DUTCH DEPENDENCIES

The Dutch once had a major trading empire in Asia, South Africa, and the Americas. With Suriname's independence in 1975, that empire has now all but gone.

ARUBA

Island off the coast of Venezuela.
1499 Island first claimed by Spain.
1636 Acquired by the Dutch. At first is left to the indigenous Arawaks.
1848 Becomes part of the Netherlands Antilles.
1954 Netherlands Antilles gain internal self-government.
1986 Aruba becomes a separate Dutch dependency.
1994 The transition to independence is halted over lack of economic viability and fears for the island's security.

NETHERLANDS ANTILLES

Island group consisting of Curaçao and Bonaire off Venezuela, and Saba, Sint Maarten, and St. Eustasius—shared with French Guadeloupe—in east Caribbean.
1845 Netherlands Antilles formed.
1954 Gain internal self-government.
2000 Sint Maarten votes for autonomy.
2004 Bonaire and Saba vote for direct administration by the Dutch government, as does St. Eustasius in 2005.
2005 Curaçao votes for autonomy.
2010 Netherlands Antilles are dissolved. Curaçao and Sint Maarten become constituent countries of the Netherlands. The other islands become part of the province of North Holland.

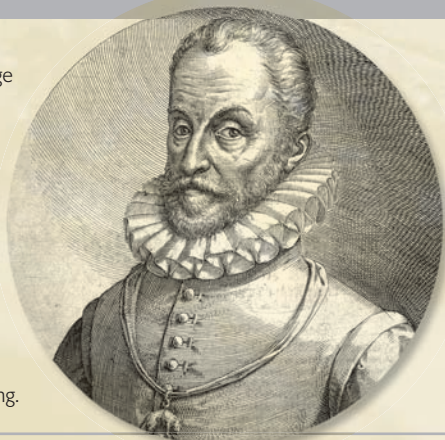
2010 Coalition government collapses over presence of Dutch troops in Afghanistan. An indecisive election gives center-right Liberal party most seats. Dutch troops are withdrawn from Afghanistan in August.

«208–09 Cities and Trade
 «238–39 Trade and Empire
 «276–77 The Birth of Capitalism
 «350–51 Colonial Resistance

DUTCH REVOLT LEADER (1533–84)

WILLIAM I OF NASSAU

William I of Orange-Nassau, also known as William the Silent, became Prince of Orange in 1544. He was the main leader of the Dutch revolt against the Spanish that started the 80 Years War and ended with the independence of the United Provinces in 1648. Unhappy with the treatment of Dutch Protestants, William joined the Dutch uprising. He was the most politically capable of the rebels, leading them to several military victories against the Spanish. Declared an outlaw by Philip II of Spain in 1580, he was murdered in Delft by a supporter of the king.



Belgium



A largely low-lying country that has been a frequent battleground over the centuries.

51 BCE The Romans complete the conquest of the Celtic and Germanic tribes in the area covering present-day Belgium; the region becomes one of the provinces of Gaul.